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Jackie Williams

Drummer Jackie Williams keeps company with some of the greatest artists in jazz. A native New Yorker, he grew up in the fertile jazz atmosphere of the City, also absorbing the dance grooves of rhythm & blues. He is a first call drummer for jazz recordings and appears with Dizzy Gillespie on Milt Hinton's "Old Man Time."

Jackie was interviewed in New York City on October 18, 1995 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, in New York City, with drummer Jackie Williams, and it's a great pleasure to be here with you. Can I call you an "in demand" drummer in New York?

JW: Oh, that sounds good, I like that.

MR: I think you are. It took me a few times to reach you so you must be out there.

JW: I'm out there trying to do something, yeah.

MR: I know that you play a lot of jazz parties and occasional cruises, and this is something that we have really just become aware of that these things are out there. What is that like to do that? Is it a good gig?

JW: It's a wonderful gig, in more ways than one. Well you get a chance to play with different artists that you haven't played with maybe in a long time, or even artists that you haven't met. So it's always a thrill you know. Each party is an opportunity to play with these people you haven't played with in a long time or meet someone you hadn't met before, and you get a chance to have a variety of settings to play in. You understand what I mean? Say there's twenty musicians or so and you might have a set of say six musicians or you get a chance to play with a different group during the time that you're there. They may do a trio setting, they may do a quartet setting, they may do a sextet setting. You know, so you have a fresh approach every time you come on, you know? So it's always nice. And you get to extend your repertoire. You brush up on some of the stuff that you haven't been doing, you know, say you've been locked in to one environment for a long time. So you get a chance to get out and hear what other people are doing.

MR: It's interesting in the jazz world, that kind of you have to, in addition to learning your instrument, you have to learn the etiquette and the repertory so that, as you mention, you might not know some of the people you're on stage with.

JW: That's right. So the thing is I mean before you go you usually get in you know, like a rostrum I would say a rostrum of the different players. So you familiarize yourself with them, mentally and musically you would just say what is so-and-so doing, what do they

do? You know that's the way I usually do. And you familiarize yourself with their repertoire, the type of things they do, and you know just like if you go on for a job with someone, you find out what their needs are. So that's the way I usually do.

MR: Right. Are you a New Yorker by birth?

JW: Yes.

MR: So you've lived here pretty steadily?

JW: Pretty steadily, except for when I go out of town a lot. Some people say well do you still live in New York? Because I do a lot of traveling sometimes, you know. But it's always nice to get back, get back to the Apple.

MR: What's a typical month like for you as far as moving around? They probably vary, but—

JW: They do vary. But if possible I like to do, especially European travel. I like to do that in the summer in the warmer months because it's much more pleasurable, you know, traveling-wise.

MR: Is there an audience difference from the United States to Europe to Japan perhaps? I don't know if you've been —

JW: I have not yet been to Japan. I probably will be going soon. But the audiences are very good here in the states, and they are exceptionally good in Europe I find, especially the audiences that are there already for you, say the colleges and things that you play for here, or concerts, you know, or the cruises or jazz parties. Those audiences are there already.

MR: And they know they're stuck too.

JW: They know they're stuck. And you get there, and they're waiting for you. So you give them the best that you can and they give you their best too. That's the appreciative part about it. And I find that the audiences in Europe are just exceptional also, because they know your history. They know you, you know, sometimes even better than you know what you've done, you know? You go over there and they say well, "I got that record that you did with the two guitar players." And I say well gee that's been so long. I did a record with two guitar players—

MR: Jim Hall?

JW: No. It will come to me before— I certainly hope so. The guitar player that was with Fats Waller. Are you familiar with him?

MR: That's going back. It wasn't Al Casey or somebody?

JW: That's who it was — I knew you could do it. Al Casey and Butler, Jimmy Butler. They were the two of them and the drum. Anyways he was Hugh Panassie's son, who had this little, you know, recording company like. And he wanted to record different people so they said let's put this together. So it was his idea to put us together. He had recorded Jo Jones with the Milt Buckner Trio, you know and Illinois Jacquet and all this stuff. So

they said well let's get this, that was his idea to put us, the three of us together. And it worked out beautifully, you know? So when I go overseas sometimes, people say, "I still have that record." I say, "Which record?" And they'll tell you this record and I say, "Gee whiz, I forgot all about it."

MR: Well it's funny that you're not the first person I've talked to that may not have the records that they played on. Now to me, I say boy I want every record I played on.

JW: That's true, what you're saying. Now that record, it's hard to get. It's on Odyssey label. And I've been overseas another time with Slam Stewart, Johnny Guarnieri, Pat Flowers and we did a tribute to Fats, it was called a "Tribute to Fats Waller." And oh we recorded a lot of wonderful tunes. And some of the stuff that was recorded on Black & Blue, and Slam did some things with Johnny, who he had worked with quite a bit long before, you know with Prez and all those other guys. And so when we recorded that I got a chance to meet Stephane Grappelli while I was there, and he decided he wanted to record with us so he recorded with us. And there's so many wonderful things that you do sometimes, just on the spur, while being on a certain scene at a certain time, you know? And that was a wonderful experience. And from that people come and say, "Well I have a record of you" with, you know that particular instance, with Johnny Guarnieri and Slam and that one with Johnny Guarnieri and Slam and Stephane. So you never know when somebody's going to come up with something that you did. That's the beautiful thing about recording. Because your work can go to places that you don't go yourself, you know? That's the beautiful thing about it.

MR: And when you look at some of these great artists like Milt Hinton and so forth — it must be such a thrill to play—

JW: Yes. Milt has to be in every home there is, and so justifiably so. He is just such a great artist and human being. He's just wonderful.

MR: Has recording, the process of it, changed significantly over the years, since you started recording? The actual studio presence?

JW: Well I imagine it has come to a lot of technical changes. They use a lot more technologies now. I wasn't there in the beginning like say Milton or a lot of the other musicians were, but I could tell that they utilize a lot more things, you know, machinery and microphoning and things like that — unless you tell them that you don't want all that. You know sometimes you can tell them, if you're being over miced or if there's something wrong with the way they're doing it, you could make suggestions. But they're going to do what they're going to anyway.

MR: Yeah. They say, "Yeah, yeah," and then after you leave it's like—

JW: Yeah well I don't know why I asked in the first place. But all in all they work it out, you know, to always try to reach a happy medium. Because basically the music is the most important thing, you know. Everyone wants a good product.

MR: How long do you usually spend, like with Junior Mance, how long do they usually give you to do an album like that?

JW: The last one we did, "Blue Mance" well they gave us almost, we did it, we did it, we took the whole day, as long as we wanted to do it. And we were not pressured to do it in a certain amount of time. But we had, we did what we had to do over, what we had to do over we did over. What we didn't have to do we left alone. Sometimes you could be too picky and the more you try to do something, the worse it gets. So you just have to know when to say hey, well that's it. It's not going to get no better. Sometimes the first take is good, you know, or the second or third take.

MR: How did you come to be a drummer?

JW: I've been wondering that all my life.

MR: Where did I go wrong?

JW: I've been wondering about that. Well I guess I was always destined to be one I guess, although I like music, I was just infatuated with music for as long as I could remember from a kid. I was always, you know kids roll up paper and blow in it imitating a horn or they'd be beating on something. So I was always fascinated with music. I could remember — I liked almost every instrument I heard. And I could remember listening, staying up nights, you know, listening, with my ear glued to the radio listening to music. Because then, as I was growing up, they had music going on all the time you know. There was radio programs, you know they had bands on the radio. And well I grew up in New York and in Harlem there was always some place where music was being played. You know there was clubs. And so I guess I just migrated to the drums through hearing music, seeing other people play, and just having a little talent and initiative to pursue it. Because I do remember studying a little piano — a cousin of mine was studying piano — and I always used to like I said always dabble around with the keyboard and stuff like that, you know just by ear and things, picking out melodies. So I heard, through hanging out through the rest of the kids, they would have little schools, you know, where kids could go and study an instrument. So I remember one day in high school one of the kids came by and said, "Have you heard about this particular school on Mount Morris Avenue, they have a great school, guys go over and play." And this particular guy I think he was playing and studying saxophone or something. And everybody was emulating the different musicians, you know like Max Roach or Lester Young or somebody. I said, "Gee I think I'd like to go over to check it out to see what's happening." So I went over there and I, you know, I was introduced to the teacher. His names was Mr. Brooks, I'll

never forget him, Aubrey Brooks. And he gave all the kids a wonderful little like screening, you know, to see what talent they had. So I told him I would like to study some drums, you know. So he was showing me a few things. This is the pad, he started out with the pad and as time went on, we had the classes there, he taught the rudiments of music, you know, not only the drums he taught theory and all the scales and everything, which was so wonderful. And the school was really nice. Because it gave the kids an incentive, you know to have something to do rather than to be hanging out on the streets all the time. So that's where I really got an interest in it you know. And he made it even more interesting by inviting certain celebrities from the theatrical world to come. He'd say well next week — or a couple weeks from now we're going to have Bojangles, Mr. Robinson, you know. So Bill Robinson is going to come and I want you to have a nice program prepared for him. And so I say "what!" So we all were very enthusiastic. So he got a wonderful little drum choir like together for us. And we all had, all the people that were playing the drums filled in with percussion. He had somebody playing tenor drum, the snare drum, tambourine, whatever. You know he was very creative that way, and he would create rhythms and stuff. And we all had our parts you know. That's the first time I ever was aware of playing an ensemble thing.

MR: How they fit together. What's the role.

JW: Right. And how everybody was important you know. And Mr. Brooks put that thing together and we did it and Bojangles came, Bill Robinson came in and he spoke to us and he was so uplifting. You know he was so proud to see us. And we were proud to see him. And so he was so complimentary to all of us. And that was a real boost to us. And not only our class, but that particular school was good, it had vocalists, it had other instrumentalists, you know, violins and stuff like that. But just a wonderful school. So in the process of doing that, Aubrey Brooks said, "Well you know you've got to have a little extra time I'd like it if you get a chance," because this is a school, "if you get a chance, one day I would like for you to come and study privately — you know I want you to kind of stretch your talent a little bit." So I say okay Mr. Brooks, but you know, when I get a chance. And as time went on, I finished junior high and then I went to high school, and I was, I majored in art in high school. I didn't go to music and art, you know, like most kids that wanted to — because I was into art also, you know like drawing and commercial art. So I studied but I think I was leaning toward the music. Because I would always be in the band room, you know, messing around with the drums and stuff. So finally the musical director of the high school, Mr. Klinger, he said, "Well why don't you join the band since you're in here all the time?"

MR: Make you work now.

JW: So eventually I joined the band, you know, the high school band around the sophomore year. And it was wonderful. He had me doing a lot of nice things. We did, you know naturally the Monastery Garden and you know, orchestral things at that time. They wasn't doing much jazz. But he would, I remember one of the assemblies, the main assemblies he knew that I liked jazz and I was into the jazz thing so he had me do a little demonstration on what I knew about the xylo— they had a little xylophone there and I would make up little programs with the — actually it was the bells and the tympani and the snare drum or something. So it was so nice, and it was encouraging because the kids were really enthusiastic about it. So little things like that just led me on to say hey, maybe this is what I should be doing, you know?

MR: Yeah. Most of, a lot of the people we've talked to have had instances in their youth where some one person really made a difference that paid off.

JW: Sure. It makes a difference, a big difference. Someone to give you that push, you know? Say hey, why don't you do that, and just press you on to it.

MR: When was your first like professional gig?

JW: A gig? Gee I can't, it's hard to really pinpoint my first professional job although I know I played, I had a set of drums and I was playing and people would call, they knew I could play drums, so they would call around, you know the different people in the neighborhood that had dances or something like that. They would call. They would call me and say well hey man I got a gig or something like that. A dance. There were a lot of dances and stuff then, you know, which was beautiful. So I did a lot of those things. But I couldn't really pinpoint the first time I played a — it's hard for me to really pinpoint.

MR: The dance thing comes up over and over and over, connected with jazz, you know that it is and was a dance music. And from a drummer's standpoint, I would imagine that you had to really pay attention to what worked with the dancers.

JW: Oh, certainly, sure, sure. In the first place, the most important thing was to have good time. You have to have good time because they'll let you know. They'll say well what's going on up there with this band. They're the first ones to let you know, the dancers, you know, good dancers.

MR: What kind of dances were they doing at this point? What year was it?

JW: Fifties. Late fifties. Medium fifties, you know. Yeah, medium fifties, late fifties around that time, going into the sixties. Well they were doing the Lindy, formal, like ballroom, they were doing mambos. The mambo was coming out. Then a lot of Latin and mambo and stuff like that. And calypso, they did calypso, jitterbug, swing-type dancing, ballroom dancing, and they always did some kind of creative things, you know. So I used to get a lot of gigs playing with some groups, local groups and I remember one time, this is a funny story I have to tell this one. I had a new set of drums set up in my grandmother's

living room and I was staying with her at the time. And somebody had given my number, I don't know if it was Major Holley or Joe Medlin, whoever, but I got a call, they said, "Jackie, are you playing tonight?" I said, "No." They said, "Well we got a job, we have to have —" "Well," I said, "I don't know, I'd been trying, I had just took them out of the boxes, they're all—" They say, "Well we're in a hurry, we got to have you right away, we're coming to get you." I said, "Well wait a minute." They said, "No we can't wait. You're not working so we're coming." And I said, "Well wait —" And I said, "Okay, come on. But I got to put all this stuff together, it's all scattered all over." They said, "Don't worry about it we'll take care of it." So they got there, it was Joe Medlin the singer, and Major Holley came. They're playing for Tiny Bradshaw. They said, "Hurry up. Let's get this stuff here." I said, "Well gee whiz, you know, I'm not dressed." They said, "Well go on and get dressed, we're going to put this set together." So I say oh Lord, why did I get into this? So finally we got it all together — they got it together. So we're on the way out to Jersey to this I think we was playing at the Mosque or one of those places out there. And you know, we were in the tunnel, the Holland Tunnel coming across. And I said, "You know, something is wrong here. I don't remember putting something — packing something — I think the foot pedal." They said, "Don't worry about it, you've probably got it." And I'm thinking to myself, you know how you get that feeling, and all that rush and hurry you know. So we got there, and I'm setting up all these drums and everything. And there's no foot pedal. And I said, "I knew it, I knew it." So, and I asked Tiny Bradshaw, who was a stomping band, you know, he wanted to hear it you know? You know Tiny and those guys, they were known for that strong beat.

MR: The shuffle thing, yeah.

JW: And especially the foot. So I'm playing and you know Major's looking at me. And so finally, Joe said, all right Jackie. Art Blakey was working not too far from there. Thank God he was working close by. So they went up and told Art Blakey, and Art sent me a foot pedal. So I finished the gig out. But it was so funny at one point because after that happened, Major says, "You mean to tell me you worked me to death?" You know how funny he is. And he would stop people, and he would put yeast in the story. And I'd say now Major, don't lie, it was just the foot pedal that I left. He tells people, "You know what he did? He came on this gig with a brand new set of drums — no sticks, no brushes, no nothing. And he worked me to death." So I said, "Why Major, I know that you're such a great bass player, I figured you didn't even need it." And he'd say, "Why you!" He was so beautiful. We had so much fun together you know. We worked together quite a bit even since and after that you know. He was just such a great player. I sure miss him too. He was a wonderful player. But that was such a hilarious experience.

MR: Who are some of the vocalists that you've had a chance to work behind?

JW: Oh, I had the great pleasure of working with one of the great ladies actually, Miss Maxine Sullivan, and in fact I did a few recordings with Maxine. And I think one of the last things they did was a Burton Lane songbook, and we did several things. And she was a joy to play for. Also Carrie Smith, I played for Carrie a few times. Abbey Lincoln I played for a long time ago. I remember we did a trio thing with Abbey. We played at a club out in Jersey — Teddy Powell's. And that was a wonderful experience playing for Abbey. She's quite an artist also — most original, even today, she's always been original. And some of the other vocal, those are the ladies. The gentlemen, uh Joe I played for, Mr. Joe Williams. Joe was a joy to play for — not on a steady basis but on certain occasions you know. I remember doing a wonderful job with Joe. On this particular one he was asked to do, he was featured doing Ellington music. And I've always associated him with Basie and the blues. But this is why I say he's one of the exceptional musicians. He's a musician. There are some people that are vocalists and different — but he's a musician as well as a vocalist, and he just knew that music so well. We did some Ellington things I think in the beginning. He had the drama of it. He had the inside of it, you know he just goes inside of a thing. It brings out the whole essence, the gist of the message. He's a fabulous performer. He did that — Ellis Larkins was his musical director at the time. And I had been doing some things with Ellis, and I did a few recordings with Ellis, who was I guess most vocalists consider one of the ultimate accompanists. He accompanied Ella and just about everybody. Well that particular concert, Joe did such a magnificent job. And since it was a Duke Ellington concert, Al Hibbler was in the audience and Joe invited — you know Joe gave him such accolades you know, he just — which he was due you know. But after maybe Al meant to come up and they would do a duet, but I don't think Al was feeling that well, you know his voice may have been a little under so he decided he would just listen. And he was so happy and he applauded us and everything. And that was a great event. And I had another chance to play with Joe. We were on a cruise, the cruise again, and at one point they had different artists, you know a group of musicians would get together and Joe would sing with us. That was real great — that was more impromptu. But he's so good at it. You know he's so free, you know he's so relaxed. His mannerism. It goes such a long way. He knows how to relax an audience, relax the musicians, you know, it's all business. Now needless to say he knows what's going on you know, but he always has that stage presence to make you feel relaxed. You know he relaxes the audience, he you know, he just communicates. That's why he's such a great artist.

MR: When you, you kind of caught the tail end of the heyday of the big bands I guess, after they kind of had a tough time after World War II. Did you get to do much big band playing because of that?

JW: I didn't do too much big band, very little big band myself, except like I said if I played some local dances. But I did have a chance to play with one big band that I enjoyed. They assembled a big band for Earl Fatha Hines, and we played at the Riverboat. And I did a week of that with him and then I went on to do something else. But that was wonderful. Well I had been out with Earl for a while. We had dome some quartet things. Oliver Jackson, my wonderful friend Oliver who is gone now — I sure miss him also, he was a great drummer. Oliver was with Earl at the time, and he was going to go with Kenny Burrell for a while. And so he asked me would I, and I say sure. He said, "Earl would like you to come and play." So I went with Earl for a while. We move around like that. That's the beautiful part about music, you know. You get different experiences working with different people. So I worked with Earl, Budd Johnson, Bill Pendleton and myself and we had a wonderful time with the quartet. We went everywhere. So after we did a tour of the states, most of the states, Earl was getting ready to go to Russia so he asked me if I would like to go. I said, "Well now, Earl, Oliver should be coming back to make that tour." He said, "Well if he doesn't, you know if he's tied up, you know you're welcome, you can do it if you want to." I said I was very appreciative of that. I said that's great, thanks. I said well Oliver's going to come back and he's going to go to Russia and do that tour. And I went and did some other things and but we did, before I left we did have a chance to do a big band thing down at the Riverboat Room in New York. And that was nice. The good thing about that, Ella Fitzgerald was also on the bill with her group, Ed Thigpen was the drummer with her, and it was great, and so it was the two groups. And after that I did occasional big band things with maybe if Buck had a dance or something like that, or somebody you know, a commercial, some leader would call me for a date, a club date type thing with a big band.

MR: What kind of, have you done any non-jazz kind of work? Done any rhythm & blues, that type of thing?

JW: Oh, sure, sure. I did many of those. Prior to getting into more jazz, I used to do quite a bit of what we call Rhythm & Blues and entertainment type group things. They were a lot of fun you know, and very beneficial to your growth also because you get a feeling of entertainment, which all music is, you know. And no matter how serious it is, it's still supposed to be entertaining. I remember playing with a group, Johnny "Guitar" Saunders, he was a guitar player naturally, and he had a nice entertainment type group. He used to do a lot of things like "Night Train" and stuff, you know those things in the day were very popular. "Night Train" and "Honky Tonk" and stuff like that. But those things were joyful to play. You know the people really liked that. We used to go to a lot of different places. We used to play up in your area — up in Buffalo, Buffalo, New York and Rochester. They had a lot of that kind of stuff in Pennsylvania. We used to go out there

and play the Pueblo Club. And I played with that group a lot for a while. Then I played with another wonderful trio, Eugene Smith. He was very entertaining. He would do a lot of piano, stand up and play the piano and sing and do stuff like that. You know like Maurice Rocco, but Maurice Rocco used to dance. He was a tremendous dancer. And he would dance and play the piano. "Boogie Woogie" and everything. Eugene is very good like that. And he used to idolize Dorothy Donegan because she was such a great performer. And he was very fond of Dorothy's playing. But Gene was a natural entertainer, as well as he played wonderful piano, but he was more of an entertainer. So I used to do a lot of work with him. And we played a lot of the clubs in New England and some in Canada in the Ontario area, and we used to do a lot of travel. Boston. We went to Boston and we played Wally's, a place called Wally's where all of the, most of the jazz players would come and play. And that's when I was at Wally's, that's when I first, with Eugene Smith, I first met Alan Dawson, the great drummer from New England. And I met Mae Arnett. She was a wonderful, great singer. And I met them there — and then Jaki Byard in Boston at that time. And he was playing — you know Jaki plays alto saxophone. And he came and he was playing alto sax. And I said well, "This guy plays so great" but I didn't know it — he played piano. But when I first met him, you know, that's all he — but you know as time went on we worked together, not too long ago we worked together, I realized that he was a great piano player. So in all these travels, in different settings, you hook up with so many different things. And they're all like a puzzle, they all come together. That's the beauty of music.

MR: Tell me about playing on this particular recording with Milt.

JW: With Milt? With the Judge? Oh that was wonderful.

MR: There's a great picture of you in here with—

JW: The Diz?

MR: Yeah.

JW: The Diz and Judge—

MR: With that cigar in his mouth.

JW: Well that was a thrill automatically with just those two guys. The thing is, John Bunch said, "Well you guys took a picture and I went home." John Bunch was supposed to be in this picture. Yes. Because he said, "Well Jackie, you guys took a picture and I didn't know you guys—" I said, "Well I didn't know either," nobody told me until after, see I had my coat on, and they said, "Well come on." I thought I was ready to go and they said, "Well come on we got to take a picture." Well we had all met — Hank called and said we're all going to go meet over at Dizzy's house, we went over to Dizzy's house. And so we waited for Diz and Diz came in and then we went on over to Rudy VanGelder's, you know, and did the date. Well Judge is so fabulous, you know. He had so many different

369 players but this is the one where everybody played — different age groups. Yeah. He's so
370 fabulous. We had a wonderful time doing this. While we were doing the session, Dizzy's
371 so comical, he was showing, he had this what do you call those things that they write
372 down, you know like a memo book.
373 MR: Was it computerized?
374 JW: Yeah, a computerized one. He had one of those things that had locked on him and he
375 couldn't get —
376 MR: He didn't know where to go next.
377 JW: But he was telling us that story and boy he had everybody cracking up. When he tells a
378 story you can't help but laugh — it was immediate laughter, the way he tells a story. He
379 say he had this thing and he was somewhere and he lost it and he said well I don't know
380 what to do. You know what? Somebody found it and they opened it up and returned it to
381 him. Well he was so happy. He said that was the greatest thing that could happen to me.
382 But he was describing how the good, all the wonderful things that happened since he had
383 that thing, you know it made things so much easier, until he lost it.
384 MR: Yeah. When you've lost it then you've had it.
385 JW: But Dizzy is so phenomenal.
386 MR: He's funny.
387 JW: He's so funny. We had such a good time.
388 MR: I have to just relate a story of my own quickly. He was playing a jazz festival in
389 Syracuse. And the Mayor of Syracuse came up and proclaimed "Dizzy Gillespie Day"
390 and Dizzy must have been in one of those moods, because he came up to the microphone
391 and he just went "no shit." You know and there was all these people. And I don't know I
392 think Mayor went just— He goes "I'm overwhelmed." And that voice he had made it so
393 much better.
394 JW: The voice — it would just crack you up you know. He was so funny. God that man was
395 funny. He didn't even have to open his mouth sometimes. He'd just walk on the stage and
396 you'd start laughing. He'd make those gestures. But he was a natural performer and
397 entertainer also. Heart big as gold. Yeah he was beautiful. Well Judge was so, as he
398 always is, so gracious at this thing, and he said, "Jackie I want you to do whatever you
399 want to do, just fill in and do this." And I said, "Well whatever you guys want to do you
400 know." So we did a wonderful little thing. Diz told me what he wanted, you know, he
401 didn't want, you know he was going to use a mute so he wanted something soft, not too
402 loud. So it was nice. I think it came out lovely.
403 MR: I think it did too.
404 JW: And the Judge says, "Jackie I got to apologize," he says, "I didn't see your name on that
405 thing so I don't want you to think it was—" I says, "Well Judge, don't worry about it, I'm

on there." So he was trying to — I says, "it's not necessary — it's your date, that's the most important thing." Now everybody else is around you, you know. But he's just like that you know. He wants to make everybody happy all the time.

MR: Can you quickly name a couple of the major influences on you, the drummers you listened to on the way up?

JW: Oh, wow, there's so many I listened to and still listen to. Well there's naturally there's Sonny Greer with Duke Ellington's band. I used to, you know, always glued my ear to, and there was the wonderful, great Jo Jones, Papa Jo you know, and he was just wonderful not only as a drummer but he's wonderful as a friend. He's just a wonderful guy. Naturally there's Max Roach I always, always listened to him when I get a chance to listen to Max or go see him. Roy Haynes. Roy Haynes is another master drummer. So creative. I don't care what situation you could put him in, he's going to come out Roy Haynes and it's going to sound right. Whether it's mainstream, avante garde, fusion, confusion, whatever. Roy Haynes is going to make it swing and it's going to be beautiful, it's going to be a work of art when he finishes it. He's just fabulous. And then there's a lot of the other, naturally Elvin I like. I listen to him. What he's doing is just awesome. And Buddy I always loved, naturally, Buddy, and Gene Krupa. I used to love, oh Sid Catlett, Big Sid, I always loved listening to him. I saw him, I had the thrill of seeing him at the Apollo and with the Louis Armstrong All Stars and he was just fabulous. And I never had a chance to meet him but I did have the privilege and chance to meet Papa Jo, Cozy Cole, Zutty Singleton and Papa Jo made it possible for me to meet Baby Lovett, the great Kansas City jazz drummer. And see Papa Jo took a great interest in all of the musicians. Not only the drummers, he was a wonderful man in the sense that he cared about the music and the musicians you know. And he was always trying to make sure that you were making progress, you know, just keep going forward you know, and developing yourself. He was really concerned about that. That's why I admired him you know.

MR: What do you feel about the way jazz is going right now? The future of it, and as someone who's making their living in jazz, does it bode well do you think?

JW: I think it's doing wonderful. In fact I think it's making tremendous progress in more ways than one. You don't have all the — everything changes, the setting. A lot of the settings have changed you see, especially since the beginnings of jazz. But things are supposed to change. But even in the change, the music itself still flourishes and goes along. And that's the beautiful part of it. So you don't have so many of the clubs or the dance halls or stuff. But you have the concert halls. You have the schools. Now the only thing is I would like to see more outlets for the talent. Because you have almost twice as much, many more musicians now.

MR: There's a lot of young talent out there.

JW: There's a lot of young and really good talent. I mean these kinds are just, they're on the money you know. They've really got some talent. And it would be just so wonderful if they had a place to really let it out you know, in the right way you know. Because it's not always in the book. It's not always in the studio. You see what I mean? It's not always, see what made the Joe Williams and Buddy Riches, the Jo Jones and Gene Krupa, they had a whole spectrum of outlets. They had the dances, you know, they had the carnivals and circuses and all that stuff. They got experiences from a lot of different sources you know? Movies. And you've got, that dance thing was important to give you a sense of moods and emotions you know? You could play something and it's not always going to be, rippity, rippity, you know, fast and exciting, because people are not always in that mood. So that's the good thing about the dance, dancing, you know the dance halls and stuff like that. That was very good. And it brought people together a lot you know. You get a chance to socialize and it was great. But it's really nice today also. But I'll tell you one thing, over in Europe they believe, and they have a — I was over there last, the year before last with the Alden-Barrett quintet which I recommend, when we get a chance. And we went to, they had a wonderful — we played a festival over there and one of the days they had a great festival of the big band era. They had Lionel Hampton was there and then they had a band, I forget who the leader was but it was based on Glenn Miller — it was the Glenn Miller band actually. But they played all the other big bands. The Glenn Miller band played the music of Duke Ellington, they played the music of Count Basie, they played the music of Tommy Dorsey, and they played wonderful. They just played, you know all the tunes, a lot of the music that you were familiar with with those particular bands. And that band played so good. And naturally Lionel Hampton's band just wiped everybody out. They just tore the whole place up. The just wiped everybody out. But that Glenn Miller band was very good. And it was good to see. And that place was packed — jammed. And there was young, there was old, and they was dancing. It looked like something from out of the 40s or the 50s. It was unbelievable. Everybody did all complimenting about that. And it was just beautiful. Now that's the kind of things they need to bring out more I think here. And that would really balance out that whole thing. Because they didn't lose that you see? Over there they cherish all of that stuff you know.

MR: That's interesting. A lot of people have said that. I don't know, sometimes when an art form comes from somewhere else, people treat it with more respect.

JW: They treat that with a great deal of respect. And they look forward to that particular time every year. They come out and people tell me they get stronger and stronger. And I could see that for myself. Those people were out. And all age groups. It wasn't just the people that are over 50 and 60. These are the youngsters you know? And they were doing those

dances, and they were having a ball, they were having a wonderful time. And the music was good you know. It was just great.

MR: Well what's next up for you?

JW: Well I anticipate something good.

MR: I like your attitude, I really do.

JW: I anticipate something good. I know one good thing is coming up, I get a chance to be with my buddies Junior Mance and Keter Betts, in a couple of weeks. I'm really looking forward to that. We're going to be on the jazz cruise, on the S.S. Norway.

MR: Oh, there's so many good people going to be there, oh, Lord.

JW: Yeah. In fact I got a letter from a lady from Florida, she's a real fan of ours now. She wrote a newsletter for the — St. Petersburg Florida — she says "Jack, we can't wait for you to come down for the cruise. So she wrote down for the newsletter she was on that cruise with Oscar Peterson. She wrote some of the report on that.

MR: Oh, I was on that cruise.

JW: Yeah, Hilda, her name is, I forget— Hilda. She dropped me a note with the newsletter that she wrote and she mentioned what a wonderful concert that was with Oscar and everybody and all the different artists that were there. And she mentioned it. And I can't wait for November the 4th, to hear one of my favorite groups, the Junior Mance trio, with Keter Betts and Jackie Williams. So we're really looking forward to that. We had such a great success the last time we were on the, we played the Song, the American Song Book. And this time we're going to do the Norway. And it's going to be some great talent on there also.

MR: I think Joe is going to be on that cruise.

JW: Joe is going to be on that. I hope Joe is going to be, or is he on the one before us? Joe might be on the one before us I think. Because there are going to be two weeks. But we're going to have some good people on ours also. I'm really looking forward to that. We have such a great rapport with Junior and Keter. I bet you could tell that on the record, huh?

MR: I sure can. Wonderful. All right, well it's been really fascinating talking with you.

JW: Oh well it's been my pleasure, Monk, and I'm glad that you thought of me. I'm very happy, and I hope that I've conveyed some kind of message to whoever views this.

MR: Yeah. And I like your positive outlook on the future of jazz too because to be honest with you, not everybody shares it.

JW: Really?

MR: Yeah. Some people feel that, well because the venues have changed so much, that there's just not the places that the talent can be incubated.

JW: Well I find that where there's a will there's a way, and that's the truth. Oh I didn't mention another great group, a privilege I had of playing with was Frank Wess, who is another fabulous musician of the Basie alumni. And we did a wonderful thing over in Norway, in Oslo. He did a nice recording over there. It's called "Surprise, Surprise." We did some stuff of Frank's writing and a one by Norman Simmons and also Joe Cohn, Al Cohn's son was on that, and Lynn Seaton. That's a wonderful CD. And we did some nice things. It was received very well over there. And that's another way that you could tell that the music is healthy and growing. Of course every time you go somewhere you find out that they're building, they're trying to start a little company, a recording company or some kind of a library. I think it's a healthy atmosphere. I always see something coming up. And there are good musicians out here, and they're going to get a chance to express themselves. I believe that.

MR: All right. Thank you very much on behalf of Hamilton College. It's been a real pleasure.

JW: My pleasure. And any time I could be of assistance, let me know.

MR: All right.

JW: Okay.